

OkCon 11 opens in Berlin

The Open Knowledge foundation kicks off their annual conference in Berlin with focus on innovation and open knowledge sharing

Japs invent capsule endoscope

Japanese researchers invent a capsule endoscope to navigate through the anus, it is codenamed as mermaid

Shoot in high definition

Agent 001 gets some vacation time and heads off camcorder hunting

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I finally got some much needed leave, and figured I'd head off into the hills for a vacation. Naturally, a camcorder was first on my list of much needed gadgets to carry for the trip.

A little bit of research revealed that consumable media-based camcorders are essentially fossils. The camcorder world revolves around hard drives and flash memory, so do not buy a DVD, mini-DV or tape-based camcorder today – the prices of media have risen and moreover these consumables have limited rewrite cycles. Additionally, these media cannot handle HD resolution, owing to the extra bandwidth required due to the much higher bitrates.

1080i video camcorders are not very expensive presently, and while they do command a premium over non-HD camcorders, if you're looking to buy something that won't need upgrading, this is definitely the way to go. With HDTVs also becoming cheaper and widespread, camcorders supporting direct playback on these displays, and HD codecs becoming mainstream, the ecosystem to record view and archive HD videos is in place.

Mind you, these days, camcorders are facing peril from digital SLR (dSLR) cameras. These cameras, with their relatively gargantuan sensors are capable of 1080p video capture, and at much higher detail, with a better dynamic range and less noise than compact camcorders. However, a dSLR is bulkier, typically doesn't have any in-built storage (remember these videos are space hogs), and more importantly, no dSLR comes with a 30x zoom. To use a dSLR as a camcorder, you'll have to

invest a lot more in lenses, and telephoto lenses are typically expensive. Each system has its own set of pros and demerits, but I'd say if you've bought something like a Nikon D5100 or a Canon EOS 600D, there's very little reason to buy a dedicated camcorder for video unless you consistently need a zoom of more than 10x.



Sony-HDR-XR160

I decided to look at hard drive based system. Flash-based camcorders capable of recording 1080i content are limited. Roaming around Croma, Reliance Digital and E-Zone stores, one thing was clear Sony dominates shelves in these stores. Mind you, this isn't necessarily indicative of Sony being a superior brand, but they do get a lot of shelf space – evidently flooding the market is a good way to ensure you're popular. The adage "out of sight, out of mind" comes to mind.

The staff at such store counters are generally helpful, but specific queries are likely to go unanswered. When I asked them about JVC camcorders, they said JVC isn't officially available. Similarly, queries about Samsung yielded replies like "Their camcorders are not very good, and people don't ask for them, you're the



first person to enquire about Samsung". Similarly, one guy from Croma kept telling me that these camcorders recorded full HD, when in fact they record 1080i and not

1080p. When I asked him whether full HD meant 1080p or 1080i, he couldn't respond and called a senior guy, who asked me whether I wanted a full HD camcorder or a regular one.

Canon has flash-based 1080i camcorders, but I found them a bit expensive. The Canon Legria HF M300 is a nice looking camcorder capable of 1080i recording, but priced at ₹43,000. It comes with a flash slot and no in-built storage,

which seems a little silly given that a 32GB card will store only around three hours of video – not good if you're going on vacation, or need to shoot without access to a computer for backup. I visited a Sony World and came across a couple of options.

The HDR-XR160E, in

particular, caught my eye. According to the owner, this model is a new arrival, and has a larger hard drive (160 GB) over the previous model that came with a 120GB hard drive. What I really liked was the 30x optical zoom. We purchased a Sony HD camcorder for our video reviews section two years back and that had an optical zoom of only 10x, which worked fine for in-house shooting, but won't help if you want to use it outdoors. Sony World was selling the HDR-XR160E for ₹39,990 while Croma had the same model for ₹39,499. There was an EMI option available, where I could pay in three easy instalments of ₹13,499 every month. Quickly calculating, I figured I'd only spend 998 bucks more over three months. I went for it and picked up a slick-looking case for another 650 bucks. Back to packing now... HD camcorder – check! 